Chapter 3

Literature Review

Coral reef bleaching has become a major environmental concern, and recent studies increasingly explore how satellite imagery and machine learning can improve detection and monitoring. Since bleaching signals in water are often weak, mixed with surrounding substrates, and influenced by seasonal or environmental variations, many traditional methods struggle to identify bleaching accurately. Multi-temporal satellite analysis and data-driven models have therefore gained attention for addressing these challenges.

Li et al. [1] used Sentinel-2 imagery with a multi-temporal strategy to detect bleaching in the South China Sea. Their method relied on spectral differences before and after bleaching events. While it improved detection compared to single-date imaging, it still struggled in shallow regions where sand and coral signatures overlap. Similarly, Guggenberger et al. [2] explored object-based image analysis using very-high-resolution UAV images. Their work demonstrated that manual segmentation combined with texture features could classify coral conditions more precisely, but the workflow remained time-consuming and difficult to scale to larger reef systems.

In another study, Zhang et al. [3] proposed an automated deep-learning framework that integrates image enhancement and classification networks. Their model showed strong performance, especially in low-visibility underwater scenes, but required extensive training data that may not always be available for different reef environments. A related machine-learning effort by Bhattacharya et al. [4] focused on predicting bleaching using environmental variables such as sea-surface temperature, salinity, and solar radiation. Although their predictive model performed well, it did not incorporate satellite imagery, limiting its ability to detect bleaching directly.

Springer et al. [5] examined the effects of thermal stress and oceanographic conditions on bleaching, emphasizing that ecological factors significantly influence bleaching severity. Their findings show that image-based detection alone may be insufficient without accounting for

environmental variability. Likewise, Hensel et al. [6] highlighted long-term climate drivers, demonstrating how rising global temperatures increase the frequency of mass bleaching events. They argued that monitoring systems must integrate environmental trends to provide meaningful early warnings. Another recent contribution by Chen et al. [7] used multi-spectral and environmental indicators together to improve classification accuracy, but their approach remained sensitive to noise in regions with high turbidity.

Overall, studies using multi-temporal imagery [1], UAV-based analysis [2], and deep learning frameworks [3] show significant progress in detecting bleaching, while environmental-factor-based models [4–6] highlight the complex climate influences behind bleaching events. However, most methods either rely heavily on imagery alone or focus only on environmental prediction, without integrating both perspectives. This gap motivates our proposed approach: a hybrid system that combines remote-sensing analysis with machine-learning techniques, supported by multi-temporal satellite data, to enable more reliable and scalable coral bleaching detection across diverse reef environments.

References

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